the Gita. Perform your *dharma*, Krishna tells Arjuna: do your duty regardless of the outcome. The right action in conformity with your *dharma* is your only obligation; its consequences, even its success or failure, should have nothing to do with the moral motivation for your action. Your own feelings, or prospects of reward, are irrelevant to the need to act. Krishna's philosophical advice is essentially to do what is right regardless of the consequences. Implicit is an acknowledgement that doing the right thing is not always easy, that it can cause pain and grief to others, even others one loves or is bound to. But the path of *dharma*, leading a life of good conduct—what a Westerner might call a moral life—is a complicated and ambiguous task, not to be reduced to simple calculations of defeat or failure, life or death, reward or punishment. Armed with this advice, and with Krishna as his charioteer, Arjuna goes forth to sanguinary battle, and prevails, leaving the battlefield littered with the blood-soaked bodies of his own cousins.

The *Gita* is an amazing text, full of wisdom and philosophical reason, but also a call for action, an exhortation to fulfil one's duty with conviction and courage. It has probably inspired more commentaries per line of text than any other work in the vast canons of Hinduism. Swami Vivekananda and Mahatma Gandhi swore by it; each found different aspects of its poetic brilliance and profundity to live by.

The eighteen *Purana*s (composed roughly between 250 CE and 1000 CE) convey the truths of the Vedas and the Dharmashastras in short stories as well, and have formed the basis of religious education in rural India for millennia. They differ from the Itihasas since they do not comprise a grand epic narrative but several different stories featuring non-recurrent characters. The moral code conveyed through Puranic stories is still the basis for Hindu ethics, and the characters in many Puranic tales have come to epitomise the virtues of faith, chastity, obedience, loyalty, constancy, generosity and so on. Their names are often cited, whether in conversation or even political discourse, as emblematic of those virtues: Prahalada the faithful believer, Savitri the devoted wife, Dhruva the constant, Harishchandra the truthful, and so on. The *Purana*s also tell the stories of the ten incarnations of Vishnu; and